

Your first two weeks in Chiang Mai



cnxcribs.com
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Real numbers from 43 buildings we walked ourselves. No agent fees, no paid placement. **Do not sign anything in your first week** — walk the neighbourhoods first.

1 • WHAT IT COSTS, ALL IN

UNIT	RENT	+ BILLS	TOTAL
Studio ~33m²	฿10.0k	฿2.4k	฿12.4k
1 bed ~45m²	฿13.8k	฿2.4k	฿16.1k
2 bed ~80m²	฿18.0k	฿2.4k	฿20.4k

Median asking rent plus ~฿2,400 of bills (electric at 300 kWh, water, internet). Bills are near-flat whatever the size, so they hurt a cheap unit most. Cheapest we list: ฿3,500.

2 • PICK YOUR AREA

Nimman 27 bldgs · from ฿8.0k · ฿346/m²
The digital nomad heartland. Cafes, co-working, and condos within walking distance of everything.

Old City 16 bldgs · from ฿3.5k · ฿291/m²
Temples, night markets, and affordable living inside the ancient moat. Quieter pace, rich culture.

3 • WHERE TO STAY WHILE YOU LOOK

Book **two weeks** of short-stay before you commit to anything longer. Nobody can judge a building from photos — you need to hear the traffic at 10pm, feel the afternoon sun on a west-facing wall, and walk to the 7-Eleven. Base yourself in the area you think you want, then confirm or change your mind.

A month-long lease signed from abroad is the single most expensive mistake people make here.

7 • YOUR FIRST 48 HOURS

Get a SIM ฿49–300 AIS or True. Buy at an operator store, not a tourist-area 7-Eleven — they sometimes refuse local rates.	Get cash ฿220 fee Every foreign-card ATM withdrawal is charged this on top of your own bank's fee. Take out more, less often.	Move around ฿30 flat Red songthaews cross town for a fixed ฿30. Grab runs ฿80–120. A monthly scooter is ฿2,500–3,500.	Skip the bank week 3+ Opening an account is hard on a tourist entry and needs a lease. Do it once you have signed somewhere.
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TWO PHRASES WORTH HAVING

ลดได้ไหม? *lot dai mai?* — “Can you give a discount?”

ค่าไฟหน่วยละเท่าไร? *kaa fai nuay la tao rai?* — “What's the electric rate?”

4 • THE RATE CARD

Electric	✓ 5–8 ฿/unit	✗ above 8 ฿
Water	✓ 25 ฿/unit	✗ above 35 ฿
Deposit	✓ 1–2 months	✗ 3+ months
WiFi	✓ Included	✗ check it exists

Government electric is ~4–5 ฿; every building marks it up. The rate is fixed by the building and follows you every month — check it before the rent.

5 • HOW TO PAY LESS

April	Low season — supply is high and landlords flex
6 months	Gets you 10–20% off versus monthly
Vacant units	Ask which have sat empty; those owners deal
Go direct	No agent means no one-month commission

6 • WALK AWAY IF

- ✗ Electric above 8 ฿/unit
- ✗ No written contract
- ✗ No deposit receipt
- ✗ Musty smell or ceiling stains
- ✗ No management office
- ✗ Very old water heater

⚠ VISA — CHECK BEFORE YOU FLY

Thailand’s Cabinet approved cutting the 60-day visa exemption to 30 days on 19 May 2026. It takes effect 15 days after Royal Gazette publication.

Verify the current rule before booking — do not plan a long stay around visa-free entry.

CNX Cribbs

43 long-stay buildings, checked in person.
Real prices, real gotchas, no agent fees.

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